CALL 1 · Nobody is built for this

Sun Nov 1

Nobody is built for this job.
I know. I was a CAL FIRE Deputy Chief.
Now I live with a brain injury. And PTSD from the job.

Not me. Not you. Not the toughest one on your crew.
Not the soldier. Not the medic.

We see things the human brain was never meant to see.
Then we go home and pass the potatoes like nothing happened.

That's not strength. That's a slow leak.

For 61 days, one video a day, I'm going to tell you what nobody told me.
About PTSD. What it does to us. What actually helps.

No sugar coating.

If you wore the uniform, any uniform, or you love someone who did, stay.

This is Call 1 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 2 · It's an injury

Mon Nov 2

If you broke your leg on a call, you'd get it set. Nobody would call you weak.

PTSD is an injury too. You just can't see it on an X-ray.

Trauma changes how your brain works.
The part that spots danger gets louder.
The part that says "you're safe now" gets quieter.

That's not a character flaw. That's biology.

And here's what matters. Injuries heal. PTSD is treatable. People get better.

But only after you stop calling it weakness
and start calling it what it is.

An injury. From the job.

This is Call 2 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 3 · It's the pile

Tue Nov 3

Most people think PTSD comes from one horrible call.
Sometimes it does.

But for a lot of us, it's the pile.

The kid. The rollover. The man nobody found for a week.
The one you worked for forty minutes.
Year after year after year.

Every one goes in the bag. You tell yourself you're fine.
The bag doesn't care.

The doctors who wrote the official rules for PTSD put us right in there.
Repeated exposure to the worst details. They named first responders.

So if no single call broke you, that doesn't mean nothing's wrong.

It means the bag got full.

This is Call 3 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 4 · The alarm stuck on

Wed Nov 4

Your brain has a smoke detector. It's called the amygdala.

Its job is simple. Spot danger. Sound the alarm. Flood you with adrenaline.
On a call, that saves your life.

Trauma can jam that detector in the ON position.

Now it goes off in the grocery store. At your kid's game.
At two in the morning when nothing's happening.

Your heart pounds. You scan every room. You snap at the people you love.

You're not crazy. Your alarm is stuck.

And you don't fix an alarm by yelling at it.
You get it serviced.

That's what treatment does.

This is Call 4 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 5 · The four signs

Thu Nov 5

Four signs. Learn them like your ABCs.

One. It comes back. Nightmares. Flashbacks. A smell that drops you right back on scene.

Two. You avoid. Certain streets. Certain calls. Talking about it at all.

Three. Your mood and thinking change. Guilt. Numb. "The world is rotten." You stop enjoying what you loved.

Four. You're always on. Jumpy. Angry. Can't sleep. Back to the wall.

If those hang on for more than a month and get in the way of your life,
that's not "just the job."

That's a reason to get checked.

This is Call 5 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 6 · It's not "just a dream"

Fri Nov 6

"It's just a bad dream." No, it isn't.

I'll tell you straight. For me, the nightmares are the worst part.
Some nights I wake up, and I'm right back there.

When the same call plays at three a.m. Again. And again.
That's your brain trying to file something it can't file.

Flashbacks too. You're awake, at the store,
and for a second you're back on scene.

That's called intrusion. It's one of the core signs of PTSD.

A lot of us handle it by not sleeping. Or drinking till we pass out.
Neither works for long.

Nightmares are treatable. There are therapies built just for them.
Tell a doctor. Use the word "nightmares." Out loud.

This is Call 6 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 7 · Avoidance looks like "fine"

Sat Nov 7

The most dangerous symptom of PTSD looks like you're fine.

It's called avoidance.

You take the long way home so you don't pass that intersection.
You trade off certain calls. You change the channel.
When someone asks, you say "I'm good" and change the subject.

It works. For a while.

But every time you avoid it, your brain learns the memory is still dangerous.
The fence gets taller. Your world gets smaller.

Ask yourself one honest question today.
What am I going out of my way not to think about?

That's where the work is.

This is Call 7 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 8 · Numb is not tough

Sun Nov 8

Your kid hits a home run, and you feel nothing.

Someone you love says "I love you," and you say it back on autopilot.

We call that tough. Steady.

It's not. It's numb.

On a call, shutting your feelings off is a tool. It lets you work.
The problem is, there's no switch that only turns off the bad ones.

Turn off the horror, and you turn off the joy too.

If home feels flat. Gray. Far away.
That's a sign. Not of weakness. Of an injury that needs care.

The people at your table deserve the real you.
So do you.

This is Call 8 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 9 · Back to the wall

Mon Nov 9

You walk into a restaurant. You pick the seat facing the door.
You clock the exits. You watch the guy by the counter.

You call it awareness. Everybody on the job does it.

But when you can't turn it off. At home. On vacation.
In bed at two a.m., listening for a noise.
That's hypervigilance. It's one of the signs of PTSD.

Your body is burning fuel like it's on a call, twenty-four seven.
Nobody runs like that forever.

It shows up as exhaustion. A short fuse. A body that's always tight.

Being ready is the job.
Never standing down is the injury.

This is Call 9 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 10 · Stress, burnout, PTSD

Tue Nov 10

Stress. Burnout. PTSD. People use them like they're the same thing. They're not.

Stress is the weight. It goes up on a bad shift. It comes back down after.

Burnout is running on empty. Tired. Cynical. You stop caring about the work.

PTSD is tied to trauma. The memories come back. You avoid. You're always on edge.
Your mood and thinking change.
And it doesn't go away after a few days off.

Here's the hard truth. You can have all three at once.

And a vacation won't fix PTSD.

Know which one you're fighting. Then fight it with the right tool.

This is Call 10 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 11 · Two uniforms (Veterans Day)

Wed Nov 11

Today is Veterans Day.

A lot of us wore one uniform before we wore this one. Military first. Then the fire service. The badge. The ambulance.

That's two tours of trauma. One overseas. One on your own streets.

And two cultures that said the same thing. Don't complain. Handle it.

If you're a vet who became a responder, you've been carrying a double load.
That's not a reason for shame. It's a reason to get help that understands both.

Veterans, the VA treats PTSD. Crisis line: dial 988, then press 1.

Thank you for both of your services.

This is Call 11 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 12 · The smell

Thu Nov 12

Ask any responder. Ask any vet. It's not always what you saw.
It's what you smelled.

There's a reason. Smell takes a shortcut straight to the parts of your brain that handle fear and memory.

So years later, a whiff of something. Burnt hair. Diesel. A certain cleaner.
And you're back there. Heart racing. Before you even know why.

That's a trigger. It's not weakness. It's wiring.

Here's one thing to try. When it hits, name it out loud.
"That's a trigger. I'm in my kitchen. It's Tuesday."

Naming it tells your brain: not now. Not here.

This is Call 12 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 13 · Dispatchers

Fri Nov 13

There's a responder who hears it all and never sees how it ends.

The dispatcher.

The mother screaming that her baby's not breathing.
The man who says goodbye before the line goes quiet.

They talk a stranger through CPR. Then the next call drops in.
No debrief. No ending. Next line.

Dispatchers get PTSD too. They're first responders, even when the paperwork doesn't say so.

If you've ever heard their voice in your ear on a call, thank them. Then check on them.

Dispatchers, every one of these 61 is for you too.

This is Call 13 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 14 · It shows up late

Sat Nov 14

You might think, "I got through my career fine. I'm out now."

PTSD doesn't always show up on time.

Sometimes it hits years later. When you retire. When you get out.
When the crew is gone and the radio's quiet.
When there's no next call to keep you busy.

Everything you outran for twenty, thirty years finally catches up.

I know what it's like when the job ends and your brain doesn't get the memo.

If you're retired, or out of the service, and something's off, it counts.
It's still from the job. And it's still treatable.

Tomorrow, the signs your family sees before you do.

This is Call 14 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 15 · What your family sees

Sun Nov 15

Your family saw it before you did.

The way you went quiet at dinner. The way a dropped pan made you jump.
The way you're home, but not really home.

They noticed you stopped laughing. They noticed the drinking.
They tiptoe around your moods and call it "a long shift."

You think you're hiding it. You're not.
You're just the last one to know.

So tonight, ask the people you live with one question.
"Have I changed?"

Then don't argue. Don't explain. Just listen.

Their answer is the most honest test you'll ever take.

This is Call 15 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 16 · The drink after shift

Mon Nov 16

One beer to come down. Then it's six.

After a bad shift, you need to come down. A beer does it. Fast.
Then it takes two. Then six. Then it's every night,
and the morning is worse than the call.

Here's what nobody tells you. Alcohol knocks you out, but it wrecks real sleep.
And it makes the anxiety worse the next day. So you need it more.

That's not a party. That's self-medicating.

We're not drinking for fun. We're drinking to not feel.

If you can't go a week without it, that's your answer.

Talk to someone. Before the bottle talks for you.

This is Call 16 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 17 · Anger first

Tue Nov 17

For a lot of us, PTSD doesn't look like sad. It looks like mad.

You blow up at the kid for spilling milk.
You want to fight the guy who cut you off.
Your crew walks on eggshells.

Here's why. Your alarm is stuck on. Your body's ready to fight all day.
And in our world, anger is the only feeling that's allowed.
So everything comes out as anger. Grief. Fear. Guilt. All of it.

Anger isn't the problem. It's the smoke.
The fire is underneath.

Next time you blow, ask yourself:
What am I really feeling right now?

This is Call 17 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 18 · Sleep

Wed Nov 18

Shift work breaks your sleep. Trauma finishes the job.

Twenty-four on. Tones at two a.m. Watch rotations. Your body never knows what time it is.

Then add PTSD. Your brain won't stand down.
You wake at three with your heart pounding.
You dread sleep because of what's waiting there.

Bad sleep makes everything worse. Anger. Memory. Pain. Drinking. Dark thoughts.

And if you live with a brain injury like I do,
sleep is when your brain does its repair work. No sleep, no repairs.

Sleep isn't a luxury. It's medical.

Tell your doctor you're not sleeping. And tell them why.

This is Call 18 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 19 · Your body is keeping count

Thu Nov 19

Trauma doesn't just live in your head. It lives in your body.

Headaches. A gut that's always in knots.
Back and neck pain that never lets go. Blood pressure through the roof.

When your body stays in fight mode for years, it wears down.
Research links PTSD to a higher risk of heart disease.

We're good at ignoring our bodies. We worked hurt for years.

Stop. Get the physical.
And tell the doctor what you've seen on the job. It's part of your medical history.

If you have chest pain, don't guess. Get it checked today.

Your body has been keeping count. Let somebody read it.

This is Call 19 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 20 · The one who takes every shift

Fri Nov 20

The one who never takes a day off might be running from something.

Every overtime shift. Every callback. First in, last out.
We call that a workhorse. Sometimes it is.

And sometimes, staying busy is the only way not to think.
Because when it gets quiet, it all shows up.

Work can be avoidance too. So can the gym seven days a week.
So can the garage at midnight.

If you're scared of a day off, ask yourself what's waiting in the quiet.

And if you know a workhorse, ask how they're really doing.
On their day off.

This is Call 20 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 21 · The quiet one

Sat Nov 21

The loudest warning sign is silence.

He used to give everybody grief at the kitchen table. Now he eats in the truck.
She used to come to every barbecue. Now there's always an excuse.

When someone pulls away, we give them space. We think we're being respectful.

Sometimes space is the worst thing you can give.

Pulling away from people is a sign of PTSD. And depression.
And it can come before a crisis.

So if someone's gone quiet, don't wait for them to come to you. They won't.

Go to them. Sit down. Say,
"You've been quiet. I noticed. What's going on?"

This is Call 21 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 22 · Living fast

Sun Nov 22

A hundred and ten on the freeway isn't a hobby.

Neither is the bar fight. The gambling. The affair. The bike with no helmet.

After years of adrenaline, normal life feels flat.
So some of us go looking for the rush. Or we stop caring if we get hurt.

Reckless and self-destructive behavior is one of the official signs of PTSD.

Sometimes it's also a quiet way of saying,
"I don't care if I make it home."

If that's you, that matters. Tell someone.

If you see it in a buddy, don't laugh it off. Ask,
"Do you still care if you get hurt?"

This is Call 22 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 23 · Kid calls

Mon Nov 23

Ask any responder which calls they can't shake. It's the kids.

There's a reason. You can't make sense of it. Kids aren't supposed to die.
And most of us go home to kids of our own.

So you see your son's face. Your daughter's shoes.
And the call follows you right into their bedroom.

Veterans know this too. The kids in a war zone. The ones you couldn't protect.

If a kid call is still with you years later, you're not soft.
You're human.

Don't carry it alone. Ask for a debrief after the next one.
And if it's been years, it's not too late to talk about it.

This is Call 23 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 24 · Moral injury

Tue Nov 24

Sometimes the wound isn't fear. It's "I couldn't fix it."

You did everything right, and they died anyway.
Or the system failed, and you had to go along with it.
Or you made a call in two seconds that you've questioned for twenty years.

That's called moral injury. Guilt and shame, not just fear. Veterans and responders carry a lot of it.

It sounds like, "I should have been faster." "It's my fault." "I'm not a good person."

Here's the truth. You made life-and-death decisions with what you had, in seconds.

Hindsight is not a fair judge.

Moral injury needs its own kind of help. Find someone who knows the term.

This is Call 24 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 25 · Brain injury or PTSD?

Wed Nov 25

A brain injury and PTSD can look exactly alike. I would know. I live with both.

Trouble remembering. Can't focus. Short fuse. Bad sleep. Headaches.
Noise and bright lights feel like too much.

That list fits a brain injury. It also fits PTSD.

And a lot of us have both. Responders take hits to the head. Veterans take blasts.
Mine came from COVID. My PTSD came from the job.

Here's the danger. A doctor treats one and misses the other.
Or you blame yourself for both.

If you've had a head injury or a serious illness, and you also carry trauma,
ask your doctor to look at both. By name.

That's what this channel is about. Different fire. Same fight.

This is Call 25 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 26 · The empty chair (Thanksgiving)

Thu Nov 26

Somebody at your table today is there, but not there.

They're smiling. Passing the stuffing. Answering "fine." And they're a thousand miles away.

Holidays are hard for us. The noise. The crowd. The empty chair where someone used to sit.

So here's your job today.

If you're the one who's not really there, step outside for five minutes. Breathe. That's allowed.

If you're watching someone who's not really there, don't call them out at the table.
Find them later. Just say, "I'm glad you came."

And never ask a responder or a vet, "What's the worst thing you've seen?"
Ever.

This is Call 26 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 27 · It comes home

Fri Nov 27

Trauma doesn't stay at the station. It comes home with you.

Spouses and kids of responders and veterans can start showing signs too.
Trouble sleeping. Anxiety. Walking on eggshells.
Kids who are always watching your mood.

It's called secondary trauma. They didn't see the call.
They live with what it did to you.

This isn't about guilt. It's about the truth.
When you get help, your whole house gets better.

And spouses, your hurt counts too.
You can get support even if your responder won't.
Ask the department, the union, or the VA about family support.

This is Call 27 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 28 · Five questions

Sat Nov 28

Five yes-or-no questions. Be honest. Think about the past month.

One. Have you had nightmares about it, or thought about it when you didn't want to?

Two. Have you tried hard not to think about it, or gone out of your way to avoid reminders?

Three. Have you been constantly on guard, watchful, or easily startled?

Four. Have you felt numb, or cut off from people and things you used to enjoy?

Five. Have you felt guilty, or unable to stop blaming yourself or others?

Three or more yeses? That's not a diagnosis.
It's a reason to talk to a doctor. This week.

These come from the VA's own screening questions.

This is Call 28 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 29 · The number

Sun Nov 29

More of us die by suicide than in the line of duty.

Hear that again.

A 2018 study found police and firefighters were more likely to die by suicide than on the job.
And veterans die by suicide at higher rates than people who never served.

We train for the fire. We train for the shooter. We train for the crash.
Almost nobody trains us for this.

I'm not saying this to scare you. I'm saying it because the silence is what kills.

Suicide is preventable. People who were at the edge are alive today
because somebody asked. Somebody stayed. Somebody called.

For the next two weeks, I'm going to show you how to be that somebody.

This is Call 29 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 30 · "Suck it up"

Mon Nov 30

The culture that made us good at the job is killing us.

Suck it up. Rub some dirt on it. Leave it at the station. Embrace the suck.

That mindset works on scene. It gets the job done when everyone else is running away.

But we took a tool for the worst five minutes
and made it the rule for the rest of our lives.

And we pass it down. Every time a captain says "toughen up."
Every time a crew laughs at the one who went to counseling.

I heard those words my whole career.

Culture changes one person at a time. It can start with you, next shift.

Tough is asking for help and going back to work.

This is Call 30 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 31 · The badge

Tue Dec 1

We don't talk because we're scared they'll take the badge.

Or the gun. The rig. The promotion. The clearance.

That fear is real. I'm not going to pretend it isn't.

But here's what I've seen. A lot more careers end because someone didn't get help.
The drinking catches up. The anger catches up.
The marriage. The DUI. The day they lose it on scene.

Getting help early protects your career. Waiting is what puts it at risk.

Before you go, ask questions. Who sees my records? What gets reported?
Your union and peer support can tell you. More on that in Call 41.

This is Call 31 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 32 · The joke

Wed Dec 2

Dark humor keeps us sane. Until the joke isn't a joke.

Every crew has it. The gallows humor no civilian would understand.
It's how we breathe after the worst calls. I'm not against it.

But listen closer.

"If I don't wake up tomorrow, at least I won't have to work this shift."
"You can have my truck when I'm gone."
"Nobody'd notice anyway."

Sometimes that's a joke. Sometimes it's a test,
to see if anyone will hear them.

If a joke about dying gives you a weird feeling in your gut, trust the gut.

Pull them aside. "I heard what you said. Were you serious?"

This is Call 32 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 33 · The marriage

Thu Dec 3

The job doesn't just take your sleep. It can take your marriage.

Missed birthdays. Missed holidays. Coming home and going silent.
Snapping over nothing.
Sleeping in the recliner because the nightmares wake you both.

Your spouse didn't sign up for a stranger. They signed up for you.

PTSD builds a wall in the middle of the house.
And most of us build it ourselves, one "I'm fine" at a time.

Here's the hard part. You don't have to tell them about the call.
You do have to tell them you're struggling.

Those are two different things.

And couples counseling isn't failing. It's a fire break. It saves what's still standing.

This is Call 33 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 34 · Losing the crew

Fri Dec 4

Retirement isn't losing a job. It's losing your family.

For twenty, thirty years, your crew was your people.
You ate together. Slept together. Bled together.

Then one day there's a cake, a plaque, and it's over.
The phone stops ringing. The group text moves on.

Veterans know this. Leaving the unit is leaving your tribe.

That's when a lot of us crash. No purpose. No crew.
And everything we outran finally catches up.

If you're about to retire or get out, build a new crew before you leave.

If you're still in, call your retirees.
They'll act like it's no big deal. It's a big deal.

This is Call 34 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 35 · The warning signs

Sat Dec 5

Learn these signs. Someone you know may be showing them right now.

Talking about wanting to die, or being a burden.
Saying there's no way out.
Pulling away from everyone.
Drinking more. Driving reckless.
Giving away things that matter.
Saying goodbye like it's the last time.

And watch for this one. A sudden calm, after a long dark stretch.

These don't mean someone is definitely in danger.
They mean you need to ask.

Tomorrow I'll show you exactly how.

If you're the one with these signs, reach out tonight.
988. Responders, Safe Call Now. Vets, 988 then press 1.

This is Call 35 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 36 · Ask the question

Sun Dec 6

Ask it out loud. "Are you thinking about killing yourself?"

Not "You're not thinking of doing anything stupid, are you?"
That's asking for a "no."

Ask it straight.

You will not put the idea in their head. Research says asking doesn't raise the risk.
It often brings relief. Somebody finally saw them.

If they say yes, don't panic. Don't lecture. Stay with them.

Help them put time and distance between themselves and anything they could use to get hurt.
Offer to hold their guns for a while.

Then make the call together. 988. Or Safe Call Now.

You don't have to fix it. Ask. Stay. Connect.

This is Call 36 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 37 · What not to say

Mon Dec 7

"You've seen worse." Stop saying that.

Here's what not to say to a responder or a vet who's struggling.

"You've seen worse."
"Just don't think about it."
"At least you made it home."
"You should be over it by now."

Every one of those says: shut up.

Here's what works.

"That sounds heavy."
"I'm not going anywhere."
"Thanks for telling me."
"What do you need right now?"

You don't need the perfect words.
You need to stay in the room.

This is Call 37 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 38 · What I got wrong as a chief

Tue Dec 8

I was a chief. Here's what I got wrong.

I thought if my people weren't talking, they were fine.
I thought a debrief after the big ones was enough. It wasn't. It was the pile of small ones.
I showed "handle it" every day. My crews watched me. So they did it too.

Chiefs. Captains. Sergeants. Here's what I'd do now.

Say the word PTSD out loud at briefing.
Tell your people about your own hard calls.
Check on them a week after the bad one, not just that night.

They will follow you into a fire.
They'll follow you into help too.

This is Call 38 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 39 · Peer support

Wed Dec 9

Sometimes the only person who can reach you is someone who's been there.

That's peer support. Trained responders and veterans who've walked the same road.
They're not therapists. They're the first door.

They know the calls. They know the culture. You don't have to translate.

Most departments have a team now. If yours doesn't, try your union. Or a neighboring agency.
Veterans can find peers through Vet Centers and veteran groups.

Peer support can't fix everything. But it can walk you to the help that can.

Find out who your peer support person is before you need one.
Put their number in your phone. Today.

This is Call 39 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 40 · Help you already have

Thu Dec 10

There's help you already have and probably never used.

Most departments have an Employee Assistance Program. EAP.
It usually gives you a few free, confidential counseling sessions.
Often your family can use it too.

Is it perfect? No. Some EAP counselors don't get responders.
If yours doesn't, ask for one who does.

Veterans, you may qualify for free counseling at a Vet Center.
It's confidential, and many of the counselors are vets themselves.

You earned this help. Using it isn't charity.

Find your EAP number tonight. It's in your HR paperwork or on your department's website.

This is Call 40 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 41 · Will they find out?

Fri Dec 11

"If I get help, will my department find out?" Ask the right questions first.

In general, your medical and counseling records are private.
Your employer usually can't see them without your written permission.

But there are exceptions. Fitness-for-duty exams. Certain safety situations.
Rules that differ by state, agency, and contract.

So before your first session, ask the counselor:
"Who can see my records?"
"What would you have to report?"
"Will my employer get anything?"

Ask your union rep the same questions.

Knowing the answers takes away the fear.

This is general information, not legal advice. Get the answers for your own situation.

This is Call 41 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 42 · The family left behind

Sat Dec 12

The call doesn't end at the funeral.

When one of us dies, by suicide or in the line of duty, the pipes play, the flag gets folded, and everybody goes home.

The family is already home. And it's quiet.

Spouses lose a partner. Kids lose a parent.
Crews carry the guilt. "Why didn't I see it?"

People who lose someone to suicide are at higher risk themselves.
That's not to scare you. It's so nobody gets left behind.

If you know a family who lost someone, call them.
Not just this month. Next year. On the anniversary.

The crew doesn't stop being family when the shift ends.

This is Call 42 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 43 · It's treatable

Sun Dec 13

Write this down. PTSD is treatable.

Not just "manageable." Treatable.
Many people who get the right therapy get real relief.
Some don't even meet the criteria for PTSD anymore.

You've heard forty-two calls of hard truth from me. Here's the best one.
You don't have to live like this forever.

The treatments that work best are talk therapies built for trauma.
Not just venting. Real methods, with research behind them.

Over the next few days, I'll break down the big three. In plain English.

So when you sit down with a counselor, you know what to ask for.

This is Call 43 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 44 · CPT

Mon Dec 14

One therapy teaches you to argue with the lies trauma told you.

It's called Cognitive Processing Therapy. CPT.

Trauma leaves beliefs behind. "It was my fault." "I can't trust anyone."
"Nowhere is safe."

Those beliefs feel like facts. They're not.

In CPT, you and a therapist size up those thoughts, like you'd size up a scene.
Is that true? What's the evidence?
What would you tell a rookie who said that?

It's usually about twelve sessions. There's homework. It's work.

And it's one of the most proven treatments for PTSD there is. The VA uses it every day.

Ask for it by name. CPT.

This is Call 44 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 45 · Prolonged Exposure

Tue Dec 15

The thing you avoid is the way out.

Prolonged Exposure therapy. PE.

Remember avoidance, from Call 7? Every time you dodge the memory,
your brain thinks it's still dangerous.

PE flips that. With a trained therapist, you slowly face the memory.
You tell it. Again and again.
And you face the places you've been avoiding, one step at a time.

It sounds brutal. At first, it's hard.

But your brain learns, "I can remember this, and I'm safe."
And the alarm finally turns down.

It's one of the most studied PTSD treatments in the world.

Hard is not the same as harmful.

This is Call 45 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 46 · EMDR

Wed Dec 16

It sounds weird. It has the research behind it.

EMDR. Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing.

You bring up the memory while doing back-and-forth movements.
Following a light or a hand with your eyes. Or taps. Or tones.

Experts still argue about why it works. But study after study says it does.
The VA and the World Health Organization both recommend it.

A lot of responders and vets like it
because you don't have to tell the whole story out loud, in detail.

If talking about it feels impossible, ask about EMDR.

Weird is fine. Working is what counts.

This is Call 46 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 47 · Finding the right one

Thu Dec 17

Your therapist shouldn't flinch at your stories.

A lot of us try counseling once, get someone who goes pale at the first call we describe,
and never go back.

That's not you failing. That's a bad fit.

Look for someone who knows responders or veterans. Ask them straight.

"Have you worked with responders or vets?"
"Do you do CPT, PE, or EMDR?"
"Can you handle hearing what I've seen?"

Peer support, your union, and the VA can point you to people who get it.

It's okay to try a second one. Or a third.

You wouldn't keep a partner who froze on scene. Don't keep a therapist who does.

This is Call 47 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 48 · Medication

Fri Dec 18

Taking medication isn't surrender. It's equipment.

You wear an air pack in smoke. A vest on patrol. Body armor downrange.
Nobody calls that weak.

For some people, medication helps turn down the alarm. Some help with the depression and anxiety that come with PTSD.
Doctors also have medicines that can help with nightmares and sleep.

It's not for everyone. It's not magic. It works best alongside therapy.

Be honest with the doctor. About the drinking. The sleep. The nightmares.
They need the full picture to pick the right tool.

Equipment is not weakness. It's how we come home.

This is Call 48 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 49 · Sleep as a weapon

Sat Dec 19

Fix the sleep and you fix half the fight.

I told you nightmares are the worst part for me. So let's talk about sleep.

There's a therapy just for nightmares. Imagery Rehearsal Therapy.
While you're awake, you rewrite the ending of the nightmare, and you practice the new one.
For a lot of people, the nightmares ease up.

There's a proven therapy for insomnia too. CBT-I. No pills required.

The basics help. Same wake-up time every day.
No booze to knock you out. Phone out of the bedroom.
Dark, cool room.

Sleep isn't lazy. It's where your brain heals.

Protect it like your life depends on it. It might.

This is Call 49 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 50 · Breathe

Sun Dec 20

You already carry the best tool on the rig. Your breath.

When the alarm goes off in your body, your breath is the one thing you can grab right now.

Try this. Two breaths in through your nose. One normal, one more on top.
Then one long, slow breath out through your mouth. Three times.

That long breath out tells your body to stand down.

Or box breathing. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four. Hold for four.
Soldiers and SWAT teams use it.

It won't fix PTSD. It'll get you through the next five minutes.

Sometimes the next five minutes is all you need.

Do it with me. Right now.

(Do the breaths now. Take your time.)

This is Call 50 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 51 · Move

Mon Dec 21

Your body is built to burn off adrenaline. Let it.

Adrenaline is fuel for a fight. When there's no fight, it just sits there.
Making you tight. Wired. Angry.

Exercise burns it off. Research shows regular exercise can ease PTSD symptoms,
depression, and anxiety. And it helps you sleep.

You don't need a fancy gym. Walk the dog. Lift in the garage.
Hit a heavy bag. Swim. Hike.

Twenty or thirty minutes, most days.

With my brain injury, I have to go slower. That's fine. Slow still counts.

And if you can, do it with somebody. Moving next to a buddy is half the therapy.

This is Call 51 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 52 · Know your rights

Tue Dec 22

In some states, PTSD is presumed to come from the job. Know your law.

It's called a presumption. If you're covered, the law assumes your PTSD is job-related for workers' comp. California passed one in 2019 for firefighters and peace officers.

Not every state has one. Some cover some jobs and not others.
Dispatchers and EMTs often get left out.

Veterans, PTSD can be service-connected through the VA.
A Veterans Service Officer can help you file. For free.

Don't wait for a crisis to learn this.

Call your union. Call a VSO. Ask, "What am I covered for?"

You were hurt on the job. That's not a favor. That's your right.

This is Call 52 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 53 · Talking to your kids

Wed Dec 23

Your kids already know something's wrong.

Kids read a room better than any of us. They feel the tension. They see the anger.
They know when you're gone, even sitting on the couch.

And when nobody explains it, kids fill in the blanks.
Usually with, "It's my fault."

You don't need to tell them about the calls. Keep it simple. Fit it to their age.

"My job hurt my brain. It's not your fault. I'm getting help. I love you."

That's it. That's enough.

Then keep showing up. Board games. Rides to practice. Bedtime.

Your kids don't need a perfect parent. They need one who's honest, and coming back.

This is Call 53 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 54 · Christmas Eve on shift

Thu Dec 24

Somebody's working tonight. Call them.

Right now there's a crew at a station eating a late dinner.
A dispatcher watching the clock. A deputy alone in a patrol car.
A nurse in the ER. A soldier a long way from home.

Holidays are some of the hardest days on the job.
And they're missing their own families to be there.

Take ten seconds tonight. Text one of them.
"Thinking of you. Stay safe. Thank you."

And if you're the one on shift, watching this between calls,
I see you. I've worked those nights too.

Merry Christmas. Come home safe.

This is Call 54 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 55 · The gift (Christmas)

Fri Dec 25

The best gift you can give a responder or a veteran today costs nothing.

A phone call.

Not a text. A call. Hearing a voice matters.

Call the retired guy who used to run your engine.
Call your old platoon sergeant.
Call the partner you lost touch with after the bad one.

You don't need a reason.
"Merry Christmas. I was thinking about you." That's the whole script.

For some people, that's the only call they'll get today.

Make one call. Then come back and tell me who you called.

This is Call 55 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 56 · If it's you, tonight

Sat Dec 26

If you're the one hurting, here's what to do tonight.

One. If you're thinking about suicide, call or text 988 right now.
Responders, Safe Call Now. Vets, 988, then press 1.
They've heard it all. You won't shock them.

Two. Put time and distance between you and anything you could use to hurt yourself.
Hand your guns to someone you trust for a while.

Three. Tell one person. Just one. "I'm not okay."

Four. Don't drink tonight. It makes the dark darker.

Five. Tomorrow, call your doctor, your EAP, peer support, or the VA.

You've walked into burning buildings. You can walk into this.

Stay.

This is Call 56 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 57 · If you're the boss

Sun Dec 27

If you lead a crew, here's what you do Monday.

Bring up PTSD at briefing. Out loud. Use the word.

Post the numbers where everybody can see them.
Peer support. EAP. 988. Safe Call Now.

After a bad call, check in that night. And again a week later.
That second check is the one that matters.

Tell your people about your own hard calls. If you've gotten help, say so.

If someone gets mocked or punished for asking for help, shut it down. Hard.

Your people watch what you do, not what you say.

Lead them into help the way you'd lead them into a fire. From the front.

This is Call 57 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 58 · If you love one of us

Mon Dec 28

If you love a responder or a veteran, this one's for you.

You can't fix them. That's not your job.

But you can do this.

Learn the signs. They've been on this channel for fifty-eight days.
Don't push for the story. Push for the help.
Say it plain. "I love you. I'm worried. I want you to talk to someone."
Keep the crisis numbers in your phone.

And take care of yourself. Get your own support.
You can't pour from an empty cup.

To every spouse, parent, and kid holding the line at home.
You serve too. Thank you.

This is Call 58 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 59 · What recovery looks like

Tue Dec 29

Recovery doesn't mean you forget.

The calls will always be part of you. That's not failure. That's your story.

Recovery means the memory stops running your life.

You can drive past that intersection.
You sleep more nights than you don't.
You laugh at your kid's joke, and you feel it.
A bad day is a bad day. Not a bad year.

It's not a straight line. There will be setbacks. That's normal.

I still fight the nightmares. But I'm still here. I'm still fighting.

Better is real. I promise you.

This is Call 59 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 60 · My promise

Wed Dec 30

Why I made these 61 videos.

I was a CAL FIRE Deputy Chief. I led people into fires.
I was supposed to be the steady one.

The job gave me PTSD. COVID gave me a brain injury.
I lost my words for a while. They came back as poems.

I could have stayed quiet. Most chiefs do.

But I believe this injury has a purpose. To lead again.
Not into fires this time. Into the truth.

So here's my promise. I'm not going anywhere.
I'll keep talking about this as long as I've got words.

And if you need someone who gets it, I'm right here.

This is Call 60 of 61.
Send it to someone who wore the uniform.
Different fire. Same fight.

CALL 61 · Last call

Thu Dec 31

This is the last call. Make one.

For 61 days I've told you the truth about PTSD.
What it is. What it looks like. What it costs. What works.

Now it's your turn.

Pick one person. A responder. A veteran. A spouse. Your old partner. Yourself.

Make the call today. "How are you really doing?"
Or, "I'm not okay."

Then send them this series. Start them at Call 1.

The campaign ends tonight. The fight doesn't.

This was Call 61 of 61.
Make the call.
Different fire. Same fight.